

Labs Ltd's international business, among others.

This momentum is also evident in recent appointments at global companies. Yum! Brands Inc named Chris Turner, its Chief Financial and Franchise Officer, as CEO, effective October 1, 2025. Fernando Fernández was promoted from CFO to CEO of Unilever effective March 1, 2025, succeeding Hein Schumacher in a surprise leadership change aimed at accelerating a turnaround.

Christoph Jurecka is set to take over as CEO of Munich Reinsurance Company by the end of 2025, succeeding long-time chief Joachim Wenning. At Sony Group Corporation, Hiroki Totoki moved from a combined CFO/COO role to President and CEO on April 1, 2025, with unanimous board backing for his role in driving growth strategy and investment in intellectual property and semiconductors.

Nik Jhangiani, CFO at Diageo Plc, stepped in as interim CEO following Debra Crew's departure, while Jennifer Piepszak, currently CFO of JPMorgan Chase & Co., was appointed COO in June 2025 and is seen as a frontrunner to succeed Jamie Dimon as CEO in the coming years.

Another example is Gaurav Jain, CEO of AXA SA, who took over the top role after serving as CFO for more than five years.

BEYOND THE NUMBERS

"In my entire career, I passed through various roles and responsibilities within the finance domain. Most of them were focused on financial numbers. But to become a CEO, the most important thing was when I started thinking and understanding beyond numbers," says Jain. He believes the real growth came from looking outward and engaging beyond finance. "You can't hide from managing relationships beyond your department. Effective communication, whether in managing investor relationships or engaging with the boardroom, is essential. Managing large banking relationships as a CFO is quite similar to managing investors as a CEO," he says.

Is that what makes CFOs favoured CEO candidates or is there more to it?

"Companies are seeking leaders who

Unconventional Paths to the top job

IMMERSIONS

Spend time on the ground in operations like sales, factory floors, and customer service to build empathy and grassroots insight

VOLUNTEER FOR CROSS-FUNCTIONAL PROJECTS

Take on or lead initiatives beyond finance (e.g. product launches, digital transformation); drive innovation from the inside out

"SHADOW" A CEO

Observe C-suite executives in action to learn how they communicate, handle crises, and inspire—then translate financial metrics into compelling narratives. A manufacturing CFO on a

climate non-profit board learns how to measure impact in stories, not just numbers

MAKE A CONNECTION

Connect with leaders in marketing, operations, HR, and even external experts. Let a 25-year-old explain Web3 or creator economies or social media activism

DIVERSE NETWORK BUILDING.

Rewire your understanding of influence and aspiration

MENTORING OUTSIDE FINANCE

Find mentors in sales, marketing, or product. Stay curious, learn continuously, and embrace new ideas

